the fodder scam, brought him back to Patna: mother Rabri summoned him home, and a conscious decision was taken to convert the sportsperson into a politician.

Within two years, the transformation was evident; he began giving interviews with a composure that surprised many and, in 2015, successfully contested the Raghopur seat. It was followed by a swift elevation to the post of deputy CM in the Nitish-led MGB government, before it came undone in 2017 with the JD(U) returning to the NDA. The same scenario played out again in August 2022, when Nitish switched to the RJD-Congress alliance and Tejashwi became his deputy again—only for the alliance to crumble in January 2024. For Tejashwi, the revolving door of Nitish's alliances has been both a curse and a moral on statecraft. "Politics in Bihar can't just be about arithmetic, it's also trust," he said recently, in a subtle jab at the chief minister.

Though it lasted just two years, Tejashwi managed to make a mark in his second innings as deputy CM. He focused on filling long-vacant posts in the health and education sectors and pushed for recruitment drives, signalling some intent. He even managed to cultivate an image of quiet diligence and approachability, qualities that struck a chord with the state's younger electorate. Now, on the campaign trail, he cites that record as proof of his administrative maturity. "I have seen governance from within," he tells the crowds. "I know what works, and what doesn't."

THE NDA RETORT

Tejashwi's efforts to broaden his social base have not gone unnoticed. On October 24, when PM Modi launched the NDA campaign, it was Samastipur he chose to start from. It was a conscious attempt to co-opt the socialist legacy of the former CM Karpoori Thakur, who was awarded the Bharat Ratna posthumously last year. Thakur, revered as a pioneer of the political empowerment of Bihar's EBCs, remains a touchstone across caste lines. Addressing a massive rally in his home base, with Nitish on the dais with him, Modi drew a sharp contrast between "Nitishji's tireless work for a new era" and, yes, the RJD's "jungle raj". In a deft moment of theatre, Modi asked the crowd to switch on their cellphone torches. As the lights flickered across the ground, he smiled and said, "There is a light in every hand, does Bihar still need the lantern?"

And despite rumours around his declining health, Nitish hasn't lost his ability to twist the knife in. He knows that an older section of Bihar's electorate—traders, government employees and some OBCs—continue to associate the RJD years with insecurity. At every NDA rally, the CM invokes "those bad days" as a cautionary lesson, even as Shah adds a rhetorical edge, reminding voters of "goonda raj" and warning that "one mistake could undo years of stability". In Siwan, the Union home minister pointed to Tejashwi

TEJASHWI'S TRAJECTORY

From cricket fields to politics, the RJD scion's journey charts the party's next chapter



EARLY LIFE
Born on November 9, 1989, Tejashwi studied in Delhi before leaving school in his teens to pursue cricket

CRICKET CAREER
Represented Delhi's age-group sides and was briefly part of the Delhi IPL franchise, though he never played a main-series match. A middle-order batsman and right-arm bowler, he appeared in one first-class game for Jharkhand before retiring from cricket in 2013



SONU KISHAN

POLITICAL DEBUT
Entered active politics in 2015 and soon emerged as political heir of Lalu Prasad and Rabri Devi. Won from Raghopur in both 2015 and 2020

IN OFFICE
Served as deputy CM twice—from Nov. 2015 to Jul. 2017 and again from Aug. 2022 to Jan. 2024—holding several ministerial portfolios. He has also been leader of the Opposition twice, from Jul. 2017 to Aug. 2022 and again since Feb. 2024, becoming the RJD's de facto leader

POWER CENTRE
In Jan. 2025, RJD national executive in Patna granted Tejashwi powers equal to those of party president Lalu Prasad, authorising him to amend the party constitution and allocate tickets. He had already proven his mettle by leading RJD to becoming the single-largest party in the 2020 polls



ANI

As deputy CM, the RJD leader cultivated an image of quiet diligence and approachability, qualities that went down well with the younger electorate